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The position of women in a pastoral society

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2. The married woman and her husband's family

2. *The married woman and her husband's family*

Relations between daughter-in-law and mother-in-law are particularly delicate during the early stages of a marriage because of the mutual attachment that binds mother and son. We have seen how, at the beginning of her marriage and before the birth of her first child, the new wife is entirely under the thumb of her mother-in-law, who remains in charge of her son's cows. These rights are not handed over entirely until after the birth of the first child. It is only then that the mother-in-law authorizes the young wife to have her own hut and to instal herself there with the articles given as dowry by her own parents, and, most important of all, to milk the cows from her son's herd. When the wife has had several children she can get on to more familiar terms with her mother-in-law, although she must continue to use the polite form of address, and it would still be incorrect to speak loudly, sing or shout in her presence, and shameful to spend a night with her husband at her hut. But the daughter-in-law may now eat with her mother-in-law and behave less timidly to her. They avoid all physical contact however, and should the daughter-in-law have her hair dressed by her mother-in-law, she would not lay her head on her knees, but on a stool.

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Any expression of affection between them is made indirectly. When the children get bigger they will be bearers of small gifts between their mother and grandmother. In the latter's old age, the daughter-in-law will let her have one of her daughters as a permanent household help.

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Towards her father-in-law a woman always maintains a more respectful distance, never speaking to him directly, unless he is a paternal uncle with whom she has always shared the same camp, in which case the rules of etiquette are less strict.

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If the camp is one belonging to an extended family, she will constantly have occasion to meet her husband's brothers, towards whom her attitude varies according to whether they are senior brothers or junior, The former are theoretically in line of succession to their father as head of the camp, so their sisters-in-law must treat them with respect and would not dare to enter the hut if any of them should be present. She has, on the other hand, a joking relationship with her husband's younger brothers, and they call each other "old fellow" and "my wife". This attitude accords with the custom of the junior levirate, which is always practised.

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The wives of her husband's brothers are the *fecciraaBe*, literally "those who sharp". This expression corresponds to a social reality, for they do in fact share the same conditions, all being strangers  72 living in the camp of the extended family of their husbands. As no jealousy or rivalry enters into their relations, they usually co-operate with each other in a friendly way. A woman will much sooner ask a *fecciraa* to look after her children for her than ask a co-wife to do so.

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